



The Italian colonialism in East Africa (Eritrea and Ethiopia)

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Abstract ;

Italy was among the final European nations to partake in the colonial endeavor, aiming to establish dominance in various territories to fulfill its diverse aspirations. This study delved into the Italian colonization, which, while not reaching the magnitude of British and French colonization, managed to make inroads into East Africa and establish colonies. However, Italy faced setbacks following the humiliating defeat at Adwa, leading to dashed colonial ambitions. The intricate details of this colonization were uncovered through historical analysis and descriptive methods.

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1. *Introduction*

The subject of Italian colonialism remains largely obscure to the majority of students and historians specializing in European imperialism and Italian national history. This lack of awareness is evident in the limited coverage of Italian colonial endeavors in contemporary European historical accounts. Italian imperial ventures have been largely overlooked in comparative colonial studies and European history. Consequently, there is a need to explore the colonial experience of Italy during its initial foray into colonial ambitions. This exploration should include an examination of how Italy established its presence in East Africa, the challenges encountered in the region, and the eventual conclusion of its colonial endeavors.

Thus, the historical method was chosen as the primary approach to focus on the narrative of historical facts and compare events while adhering to accurate accounts. The descriptive approach was also utilized to present events in a clear and sequential manner, facilitating the understanding of Italy's colonial experience. The research was structured with two main objectives in mind. The first objective aimed to explore the motivations behind Italian colonialism and its connection to the national context. The second objective sought to examine Italy's initial colonial venture in East Africa, which ultimately ended in failure. Unlike Britain and France, the Italian

Empire did not face nationalist revolutions from the colonized people but rather succumbed to military defeat and diplomatic challenges that weakened its presence in Eritrea and Ethiopia. Additionally, the study's goals were outlined as follows: to highlight the historical importance of Italian colonialism in East Africa and to comprehend the essential aspects and characteristics of Italian colonialism.

2. *The Italian intention for colonialism in East Africa (Eritrea and Ethiopia):*

2.1 *The historical context of Italy before the occupation of Eritrea and Ethiopia:*

Most commonly, "colonialism" refers to a power dynamic in which a minority of foreign conquerors hold dominance over a majority indigenous (or enslaved) population. For the sake of advantages that are frequently decided in a far-off city, colonial rulers make and enforce important decisions that have an impact on the lives of colonized peoples. Colonizers, convinced of their superiority and right to rule, are unwilling to make cultural concessions to the colonized people (Osterhammel, 2005, p. 17). Nonetheless, when we look back at the most notable colonial powers in history, we usually focus on European powers like Britain and France, which hegemonized a significant portion of the world, but we hardly ever discuss other European countries that

aimed to establish a presence, especially during the nineteenth and twentieth century colonial expansion.

Even so, Italy, for example, was undergoing unification. Between 1848 and 1870, a series of conflicts between Italians and Austrians constituted the Risorgimento, or "resurgence". A significant complicating factor was the differing political agendas of national party leaders and regional rulers (starting in 1867 with the Austro-Hungarian Empire). The first of Italy's three major Wars of Independence—the second took place in 1859, the third in 1866—took place against Austria in 1848 and 1849. Eventually, the Austrians were driven from most of the territory they had invaded or ruled, and Piedmont's monarchy and military might (the Kingdom of Sardinia led by the Royal House of Savoy) resulted in the unification of Italy (Esposito, 2017, p.3).

Instead of establishing a democracy or federation, as proposed by Gioberti, Cavour, and Napoleon III at Plombière, Italy became a constitutional monarchy in 1861. Charles Albert's 1848 constitution, which was modeled after the Piedmontese constitution, had a significant influence on the current one. After Piedmont's King Victor Emmanuel II was crowned King of Italy, the king and parliament, not "the people," held ultimate constitutional authority. Because of this, people viewed the newly formed Italian state as a "sham" democracy rather than one that truly

practiced democracy (Pearce & Stiles, 2006, p.127).

During the 1800s, the leaders of the Italian unification movement and the ensuing governments of the newly created nation were adamant that the creation of the "new Italy" represented the return of the Roman Empire (Vandervort, 2018, p.15).

Especially after the government faced serious geographical, social, political and economic problems due to the need to unite two extremely different regions of the country: the wealthy, semi-industrial, "progressive" north, which included Piedmont and its immediate neighbors as well the impoverished, agricultural "underdeveloped" South, the areas south of the Papal States (Pearce & Stiles, 2006, p. 128).

2.2. Italy and its motive for seeking colonies:

The immediate and direct motivations behind Italy's interest in Ethiopia and the country's predestined route to war outside of Rome's hills. Indeed, there is no mention in Italy's annals of a maniacal conquest of Ethiopia. The industrially advanced Lombard bourgeoisie opposed the idea of a colonial adventure because they wanted to consolidate their gains; Ligurian capitalist businessmen, on the other hand, were in favor of overseas expansion (Pankhurst et al, 2005, p.38)

Yet there was an organization based on the peninsula that had a global reach, even if its claim to a universal empire no longer existed, although Italy had been sidelined in recent centuries while others swept the world's oceans in search of land and the goods roamed are taken just as seriously as before (Finaldi, 2016, p. 5). Furthermore, it was not long after Italian unification in 1861 that nationalist, reveling in the euphoria of the Risorgimento, advocated rearmament. Its parliamentary leader, Crespi, declared in 1872 that Italy should "always arm, arm and arm." This was music to the ears of Italian arms manufacturers, traders and speculators of all kinds, because the Italian economy was still too fragile to offer them the prospect of new prosperity (Pankhurst et al., 2005, p. 38).

In addition, Italy had problems with the new government in the north, which initially tried to solve the problem by ignoring it. When this failed, it resorted to the completely inadequate solution of imposing the Piedmontese style of government on the south. This was inappropriate because the challenges in Naples and Sicily were rooted less in politics than in socio-economics. Most of the population was illiterate, lived in poverty and misery, and was on the verge of starvation.

Along with the problem of a densely populated country in which the majority of the population lives from agriculture. The

main crops were grain, grapes, oil, fruit, cheese, silk, hemp and flax. Nevertheless, Italy was unable to provide itself with food. This was the result of the shortage and misuse of capital in Italian society in the wake of the Socialist Revolution of 1860–1914 and the fact that large tracts of land were unsuitable for agriculture due to erosion and flooding. Nevertheless, there were strong regional differences in the type of agriculture and productivity levels (Dunnage, 2002, pp. 6-7). For this reason, several Italian liberals soon drew a parallel between colonialism and population colonization in the late 19th century (Choate, 2003, p. 65).

In the decades following unification, Italy experienced a population increase of 3,500,000 inhabitants, leading to harsh conditions, particularly in rural areas, which were exacerbated by the government's policies of high consumption taxes and reduced spending. The Italian industry that emerged during these years was unable to meet the availability of labor, leading to unemployment, underemployment and emigration. For authoritarian liberals, the only remedy against the red and black threats was a foreign war to reunite the nation (Gooch, 1989, p. 96).

This gave rise to an imperialism known as "demographic imperialism" in Italy, whose main objective was to give surplus labor a place to go (Silvia, 2010). which soon led to the greatest migration on the continent.

For centuries, workers from Italy had traveled to neighboring countries in search of work. However, due to industrialization and changing markets, long-distance migration continued to grow exponentially, tripling by 1886 and then again in 1891 and 1904 (Choate, 2003, p.65).

Since Italy was also suffering from land shortages at home, the Italian government saw Eritrea as a means to solve these problems. Between 1893 and 1896, 400,000 hectares of agricultural land were confiscated from the native Eritrean population and handed over to Italian settlers who had immigrated to Eritrea from Italy. Italian settlers received not only agricultural land that had been forcibly confiscated from the Eritrean population, but also subsidies for commercial agriculture. This land expropriation strategy infuriated local Eritreans and caused great resentment among local farmers (Iavasile, 2011, p. 47).farmers (Iavasile, 2011, p.47).

Additionally, the concept of the "white man's burden," which was based on the notion that European culture was superior to other cultures and could be modified, was the foundation of Italian colonialism (Silvia, 2010). The idea of a mission to bring about civilization and the belief that rich lands in Africa were just waiting to be exploited were also prevalent (RAZA, 2012, p.89).

The Italians were no different, only holding out for the possibility of taking their land. The natural resources of the nation also piqued the interest of the colonial authorities. Over the years, they conducted extensive mineral resource exploration throughout Eritrea, and they extracted copper, iron, nickel, and gold from the ground. It cannot be argued that despite the Italian colonial state's use of the colonized land for its own benefit through land confiscation, mining policies, and the appropriation of the natural resources on the land, the state did not make investments that ultimately aided in the development of the region and improved its general well-being. Italy made significant contributions to the nation's infrastructure development. In addition to creating relative stability throughout the colony—something that hadn't existed since—it constructed ports, roads, railroads, railroads, administration centers, and telecommunications lines to link isolated areas with the more developed coastal areas (Iavasile, 2011, p. 47).

Another reason is that by raising taxes, the government once again showed that it had no idea what problems it was facing. The cost of living went up, and as the peasants struggled to pay the additional taxes, their standard of living steadily declined. The hardest part of their lives became more difficult to manage new legal requirements and, worst of all, forced conscription that took young men away from the farms where they were needed. In order to avoid being drafted into the military, about

25,000 of them took sanctuary in the hills of Naples and Sicily in 1861. Rather, they survived as bandits. Many in the south turned against not only the property owners but also Piedmont and Victor Emmanuel II, and many joined the Mafia in western Sicily, which thrived by capitalizing on the general social unrest (Pearce & Stiles, 2006, p.128).

Historians, however, frequently ignore the difficulties in creating a unified state when evaluating the social and economic policies of Italy following its unification. Without much consideration for the ensuing social and economic problems, nationalists were primarily concerned with bringing the country together. The Italian peninsula also presented particular difficulties because of its diversity. Many different ancient states existed, each with its own administrative structures, legal frameworks, histories, cultures, and dialects. Many commoners continued to speak dialects that were frequently incomprehensible to people from different regions, even though standard Italian became the accepted language. (Duggan, 2014, P.207)

Hence, Crespi turned to foreign policy in an effort to preserve both his reputation and the "nation". His old mentor Mazzini believed that his desire for a successful war in Africa was specifically in line with Italy's "mission" in the world.

3. Expansion of Italian colonialism in East Africa (Eritrea and Ethiopia):

3.1. The Horn of Africa and the Italian colonialism:

The countries of Ethiopia, Somalia, Djibouti, and Eritrea collectively form the Horn of Africa, which is situated between the Indian Ocean and the Red Sea. This region is strategically located near the Arabian Peninsula and the Persian Gulf. The Bab al-Mandab Strait is located at the southern tip of the Red Sea, while the Suez Canal is situated at the opposite end. The opening of the Suez Canal in 1867 played a significant role in increasing the strategic and commercial importance of the Red Sea region. This development also led to a rise in the likelihood of external involvement in the internal affairs of the countries bordering the Red Sea (Selassie, 1982, p.1).

This led to a disagreement regarding control over the Red Sea coast, as local powers in the canal area and foreign interests competed for dominance. As a result, the Ottomans, Egyptians, British, and Italians all eventually laid claim to parts of Ethiopian territory. Despite facing external aggression in northeast Africa (Adejumob, 2006, p.6), a Genoese shipping company called "the Rubatino Shipping Company" took action in 1869. They purchased the Assab Bay, with Robatino acquiring the port for a mere \$9,440 USD, which was considered a great deal for such a profitable property. Robatino's intention was to profit by controlling the slave trade and smuggling arms (Pankhurst et al, 2005, p.22). Through an unspoken agreement

with the Savoy dynasty in 1882 (Negash, 1997, p.13), Italian troops later occupied the cities of Assab and Massawa sixteen years later. This laid the groundwork for the establishment of the colony of Eritrea and Italian interests in the Red Sea (Baldry, 1976, p.157). Despite the Italian government's preoccupation with domestic matters and their reluctance to assert sovereignty in the region, due to public opinion and the associated costs and inconveniences of building a colony on the Red Sea (Baer, 1967, p.1).

The Italian government's ambitious plans aimed at East Africa, where colonization seemed to be more feasible compared to other regions due to the relatively welcoming attitude of explorers and missionaries, as well as the less intense competition with other nations (Silvia, 2010, p.59).

Catholic missionaries, rather than representatives of the Italian secular order, were the ones who initially made their mark in East Africa after 1860 (Finaldi, 2016). Among these missionaries, notable figures such as Leon Des Avanchers and Padre Giovanni Stella, as well as entrepreneurs like Giuseppe Sapeto and Antonio Rizzo, played significant roles (Hess, 1973, p.95). These priests not only abandoned their church affiliation and shed their clerical identity but also pledged their allegiance to the newly raised Italian flag. Throughout their careers spanning from the 1840s to the 1870s, the language used by

these missionaries gradually shifted from terms like "conversion," "saving souls," "pagans," "sin," and "piety" to the more distinct rhetoric of the nineteenth century, which encompassed concepts such as "science," "discovery," "exploration," "race," and "progress." However, it is important to avoid overstating the contrast between these two realities. The missionaries firmly believed that Christianity was the driving force behind Europe's superiority, which they unreservedly referred to as "civilization." In contrast, the explorers and secular "missionaries" were fundamentally different in their approach (Finaldi, 2016, p.6).

Since that time, the Italians had shown a strong fascination with the Red Sea long before. In 1865, Giuseppe Sabito, a previous missionary with extensive knowledge of the Red Sea, emphasized in his publication "L'Italia e il canale di Suez" that the inauguration of the canal would bring more advantages to Italy compared to any other nation, and advised the Italian government to establish a naval base in the Red Sea (Baldry, 1976, p. 157).

Despite the fact that there existed a previous economic interest in Ethiopia as early as 1857, it was Cristoforo Negri, a distinguished geographer and the head of the trade department of the Italian Foreign Ministry, who approached Monsignor Massaya for his insights. Monsignor Massaya had been residing in Ethiopia

since 1851. Negri sought to ascertain the willingness of the different Abyssinian princes to enter into commercial agreements with the Kingdom of Sardinia (Hess, 1973, p.95).

Furthermore, during his visit to Yemen in the 1870s, Renzo Manzoni played a significant role, while Moshe Shapira, an Italian-Jewish antiquities merchant, also journeyed to Yemen in 1878. It was in 1879 that Sapito proposed the possibility of Assab surpassing Jeddah as the primary hub for Red Sea maritime trade (Naval Intelligence Division, 2005, p.279). By 1880, the "Societa Italiana di Commercio Coll Africa" had appointed an agent in Yemen to facilitate the exportation of coffee to Genoa. Subsequently, Eritrea was established as an Italian colony two years later. Despite Eritrea's official recognition as a colony dating back to the early 1890s, the Italian state showed little interest in African colonies until the early 1880s, partly due to a lack of enthusiasm and the vulnerabilities associated with the recently unified Italian state (Negash, 1997, p.13).

In 1883, the Caprotti brothers established "Mazzucchelli e Pereira" as agents for the "Mazzucchelli e Pereira" Company. As Italy solidified its position on the western side of the Red Sea, it also developed an interest in the opposite shore, posing a potential threat to Turkish influence (Baldry, 1976, p.157).

The British were the ones who provided support, encouragement, and assistance for the Italian occupation of Massawa a few years later. Preferring Italy over France, the Italians, who had control over a warm coastline extending for a thousand kilometers, felt the need to expand into the highlands where the climate was more temperate (Negash, 1997, p.13). This decision followed their participation in the Berlin Conference of 1884-1885, which effectively partitioned the remaining territories in Africa among European powers, with Italy being allocated Ethiopia due to its control of the Red Sea. The next step for Italy is to send its troops to claim their designated territory, a process that will require time and strategic advancement from Assab (Pankhurst et al, 2005, p.22).

The Italian government's decision to colonize the city of Sehati led to a conflict with the Abyssinians, who were under the rule of Yohannes IV. This move may have been driven by the Italian government leaders' exaggerated expectations of trade and status gains. However, the Italians seemed to overlook the Ethiopians' renowned reputation as courageous warriors, as demonstrated in their previous battles against the Egyptians in the 1870s and against Mahdism in the 1880s. (Stephenson, 2014, p45; Pankhurst et al, 2005, p.22).

This initial endeavor to expand resulted in an ambitious and predatory campaign in the

highlands (Pankhurst et al, 2011, p.51). However, Emperor Yohannes at the Battle of Dugale (Negash, 1997, p.13) swiftly and ruthlessly defeated it. Occurring on January 26, 1887, a contingent of approximately 500 Italian soldiers were taken by surprise and completely wiped out by a formidable force of 5,000 Ethiopian soldiers in the rocky region of Masawa, situated along the banks of the Red Sea. The news of this catastrophe took a week to reach Rome, and upon its arrival, the secretary-general of the Foreign Ministry failed to accurately identify the battle's location from the telegram. He proposed Dugali as the site, despite its absence on the map, and the name stuck. When Prime Minister Debreitis entered the room to announce the tragic event, he appeared visibly shaken, as noted by an eyewitness (Duggan, 2008, p404).

Emperor Johannes sought diplomatic collaboration with Great Britain to address the "Italian issue." In the context of peace negotiations, Yohannes consented to provide compensation to the Italians for Dugali and to establish Massawa as a trading hub (Zewde, 2002, p.57). Concurrently, the French initiated the construction of a railway line from Addis Ababa to Djibouti. This development aimed to grant Ethiopia a trade route to the Red Sea that was independent of Italian control (Clark, 1984, p.99-100).

However, the disgraced and desperate Italian government, instead of discouraging

them, was motivated by this incident to further strengthen its military presence in order to expand its colonization efforts in the region (Stephenson, 2014, p. 45). Nonetheless, facing a crippled military momentum, the Italians, led by Crispi, resorted to cunning strategies and diplomatic maneuvers to pursue their expansionist objectives. Taking inspiration from the British colonial playbook, they implemented a divide-and-rule policy, providing arms to Ras Mengesha of Tigray and other chiefs who opposed the emperor. Even during his intense rivalry with Yohannes, Menelik sought closer cooperation with the Italians. It is reported that Menelik welcomed the Italians as allies in a united Christian front against the Mahdists (Pankhurst et al, 2005, p. 24).

In 1889, the emperor encountered these opposing forces during the Battle of Metema, which took place on the border of Sudan. Despite the invaders' defeat, Emperor Yohannes himself suffered a fatal injury, leading to the disbandment of the Ethiopian forces. Just before his demise, Yohannes designated his son, Ras Mengesha Yohannes of Tigray, as his successor. However, this arrangement proved unsuccessful as Menelik emerged victorious in his claim to the throne in 1889 (Library of Congress Washington DC Federal Research Division, 1993, p.29). Recognizing an opportunity to establish a foothold in the country, the Italians initiated negotiations. Count Pietro Antonelli spearheaded a mission to pay

homage to the newly crowned Emperor Menelik II and engage in treaty discussions. The Treaty of Ucciali (Ochale in Italian) was signed in May 1889, in both Italian and Amharic languages (Pankhurst et al, 2005).

Italy had signed a series of "friendship and commerce" treaties with King Menelik of Shoa from 1883 to 1887. However, there was a disagreement regarding the interpretation of these agreements. Italy viewed the treaties as a way to create conflict between different Abyssinian powers, while Menelik believed that they were essential for supplying Italy with necessary weapons and ammunition (Adejumobi, 2006, p29).

The path leading to Wichale (Trattato di Ucciali) was marked by the presence of two treaties that can be regarded as forerunners. The initial treaty was officially ratified on May 21, 1883. It encompassed provisions for consular reciprocity, unrestricted movement of individuals, unrestricted trade, and the freedom to propagate religion. However, the most significant clauses were Articles XII and XIII. Article XII bestowed extraterritorial rights upon Italian citizens, foreshadowing the 1908 Treaty of Kolobokovsky. Article XIII, on the other hand, proposed that Shawan's foreign communications could be conducted through the Italian consul in Assab, mirroring the controversial Article XVII of the Treaty of Wichale (Zewde, 2002, p.117-118).

In the wake of the Italian defeat at Dugale and amidst retaliatory actions, the second treaty, more accurately described as an agreement, was finalized in October 1887. This agreement was reached between Italy and King Menelik II of the independent Abyssinian kingdom of Shewa. On May 2, 1889, the treaty was officially signed, resulting in the transfer of what would later become Eritrea to the Italians. The Italians subsequently renamed the region as Colonia Eritrea and declared it as Colonia Primigenia on the first day of the year 1890 (Whyte, 1959, p196).

The Wichale Treaty appeared advantageous to both parties involved, with the Italians gaining title to extensive estates in the northern region in exchange for providing Ethiopia with a loan of \$800,000, half of which was in the form of arms and ammunition (Pankhurst et al, 2005, p.24). Subsequently, a disagreement arose between the Shawan monarch and the Italians due to their differing interpretations of Article 17 of the 1889 Treaty of Watchali (Ucayali) between Italy and Menelik, with the Italians asserting that it implied a protectorate status for Ethiopia. Despite the improbability of Menelik agreeing to his country becoming a protectorate under Italy or any other nation, the Italian envoy Count Antonelli's interpretation of the treaty began to gain traction in Europe, much to the new emperor's dismay (Milkias, 2011, p.51).

On April 15, 1892, Great Britain acknowledged the entirety of Ethiopia as a region of Italian interests. Italian Prime Minister Giovanni Giolitti declared, "Ethiopia will continue to be under Italian influence and Menelik will be under external protection." Ethiopians paid little attention to such Italian bravado until 1893 (Pankhurst et al, 2005, p.25), when the treaty signed by Menelik in Italian and Amharic contained varying clauses regarding the management of diplomatic relations between the two nations. The Amharic version indicated that Abyssinia could utilize Italy as a representative in its foreign affairs if desired, while the Italian version claimed that Abyssinia was obligated to involve Italy in its foreign relations. Ethiopia was deceived into becoming an Italian protectorate (Adejumobi, 2006, p29). Consequently, three years of diplomatic discussions and disputes ensued among the European powers, Italy, and Ethiopia. The culmination was Menelik's revocation of the entire Treaty of Wichale in February 1893, when he proclaimed:

"The King of Italy, under the pretense of friendship, wished to seize my country with great dishonesty ... and because God has given me the crown and the power to protect the land of my ancestors, I terminate and annul this treaty. However, I have not revoked my friendship. Know that I do not desire another treaty other than this one. My kingdom is an independent

kingdom and I do not seek anyone's protection" (Milkias, 2011, p.51).

On February 27, 1893, Menelik demonstrated his rejection of the Italian version of Article XVII of the Wichale Treaty by sending letters to the heads of European states, notifying them of his accession. In December, he further expressed his discontent through a circular letter, addressing the European powers and complaining about the prohibition they had agreed upon, which restricted the provision of arms to Africa (Milkias, 2011). Menelik made it clear to the European powers that he refused to accept the Italian declaration. He boldly declared, "Ethiopia has no need of anyone; it reaches out to God." As tensions escalated and war with Italy seemed imminent, Menelik issued a declaration of militarization. This declaration aimed to foster religious solidarity within the Ethiopian Church and unite Ethiopian society in the face of Italian aggression (Adejumobi, 2006, p30).

In an uncommon demonstration of integrity amidst the warring parties, Menelik also made attempts to establish treaties with Russia, Germany, and Turkey. Notably, Menelik displayed his commitment to honoring the treaty loan by repaying it with three times the specified interest, as documented by Pankhurst et al (2005, p.25). However, the Italian colonialists swiftly found themselves engaged in a significant conflict with Menelik's army, only to suffer a resounding defeat at the

hands of the Ethiopian peasant army. This battle stands as one of the most remarkable encounters in the annals of world history, as highlighted by Milkias (2011).

3.2. The Battle of Adwa (March 1, 1896):

Initially, the Italians avoided conflict with Ethiopia as they completed their relatively uneventful occupation of Eritrea, which officially became the first Italian colony in 1890. However, in 1882, the French established a protectorate on the port of Obock (Djibouti) in what would later be known as French Somaliland, and in 1884, the British did the same further south on the coast opposite Aden, leading to the creation of British Somaliland. Subsequently, Italy, feeling impatient, decided in 1889 to establish its own protectorate over a significant portion of Somalia that was still independent from foreign control, with plans to expand it into the territories of the Ethiopian Empire. Meanwhile, Emperor Menelik II managed to mobilize a force of at least 80,000 warriors, but the Italian government was encouraged by the relative ease with which its troops had taken control of Eritrea and subsequently engaged the Sudanese Mahdist raiders. In October 1895, Major General Baratieri led a force of approximately 14,500 men in an attack on the Ethiopian Empire from Eritrea (Esposito, 2020, p3).

The Eritrean governor, General Oreste Baratieri, led an expedition into Abyssinia in December 1894, but failed to engage the

enemy in a decisive battle. In January 1895, he strategically withdrew to a more defensible position near the border, hoping to goad the opponent into attacking him there, knowing that this approach would give him an advantage in terms of rifles and artillery. Baratieri commanded approximately 20,000 troops organized into four brigades with fifty-six artillery pieces, while Menelik, leading his forces personally, had around 100,000 soldiers, although not all of them were armed. Opting not to engage under Italian conditions, Menelik's army advanced to Adwa and held their position there throughout February (Stephenson, 2014, p.46).

By the end of February 1896, the Italian military forces were stationed around Mount Anticho in Tigray. Led by General Baratieri, who had recently returned from Rome, the 20,000 Italian soldiers and local assistants in the Italian army were prepared for a potential Ethiopian assault on their fortified positions, similar to previous encounters. However, when no such attack occurred, Baratieri devised a surprise offensive against the Ethiopian forces gathered near Adwa. Given the size of a contemporary European army, along with its disciplined and well-equipped units, defeat seemed highly unlikely. A decisive victory over the indigenous population would have allowed Italy to establish a significant new empire (Pankhurst et al, 2005, p.27).

Menelik, a seasoned soldier and a natural-born courageous warrior, demonstrated his military prowess by implementing mass conscription and mobilizing his forces to a staggering number of over 100,000. In a remarkable display of leadership, he led his army northward, facing off against a combined force of approximately 8,000 Italians and 10,000 Eritreans (Coquery-Vidrovitch & Baker, 2009, p.83). Menelik's exceptional skills as an expert field commander and military tactician allowed him to inspire unwavering devotion and loyalty from his troops. The arduous journey from Addis Ababa to Adwa, spanning hundreds of kilometers, was a testament to the ethnic diversity and magnitude of his campaign. His army, relying on the strength of thousands of animals such as mules, horses, and donkeys, marched on foot, highlighting the logistical challenges they overcame (Oluwafisayomi, 2019, p.5).

The confrontation occurred in the elevated regions of the northern Tigray province (Oluwafisayomi, 2019, p.5). It commenced shortly after 5:30 a.m. on March 1 and by midday, it had nearly concluded. The encounter proved to be an utter catastrophe for the Italians, and the Battle of Adowa has been accurately characterized as "the most devastating defeat ever suffered by a colonial power in Africa" (Stephenson, 2014, p.46), resulting in approximately 11,000 Italian soldiers being killed, wounded, or taken captive. This calamitous event served as a source of international

humiliation for the fledgling kingdom (Esposito, 2020, p.4).

The retreat to Eritrea saw approximately 9,000 survivors, with half being Italian and the other half locally recruited. Tragically, senior officers Dabormida and Arimondi lost their lives, while Albertone was captured by the enemy forces (Stephenson, 2014, p.47). The Italian defeat can be attributed to the lack of coordination among the three columns. Albertoni's brigade, due to a misinterpretation of the map, became isolated and faced the full force of the Ethiopian army. In an attempt to aid Albertoni, Dapormida made a fatal error by veering to the right instead of the left. Despite causing significant Ethiopian casualties, the Italians suffered a decisive loss, leading to the conclusion of the Battle of Adwa by mid-day on March 1. This defeat marked the end of Italian colonial aspirations, as an independent Ethiopia emerged victorious (Zewde, 2002, p.122).

3.3. The implications of the Battle of Adwa:

- In Italy:

Adwa stands out in history as the most significant military encounter between Africans and Europeans since the time of Hannibal in 200 BC. It marked a moment of triumph for Ethiopia and a catastrophic defeat for Italy. The Italian colonial forces faced severe losses, with their artillery units completely destroyed. Furthermore, one of their four generals was taken

captive, while the other two generals and a significant number of their staff officers lost their lives (Milkias, 2011). This defeat brought immense international humiliation to the fledgling Ethiopian kingdom. From a purely military perspective, it represented the most devastating setback suffered by a European military during the colonial wars. Despite being equipped with modern firepower, the Italian division-sized force was decimated by a predominantly tribal adversary (Esposito, 2020, p4).

The sequence of relatively simple colonial triumphs, the first ever achieved by their military, came to an unexpected and distressing conclusion. The governmental figures had not primed the populace for a loss in Africa, much less a comprehensive catastrophe. As Pankhurst. (2005) noted, "Everything but honor has been saved" (p.29). Ultimately, a more profound adversary left its mark on the primary actors in the conflict and, most significantly, on Ethiopia. In Italy, the news of the defeat was met with a conflicting blend of jubilation and apprehension, with cries of "Viva Menelik!" echoing through the streets of Rome and other major Italian cities. Furthermore, nearly 100,000 individuals signed a petition demanding Italy's complete withdrawal from Africa. The defeat served as a validation of the anti-colonialist faction in Italian politics (Zewde, 2002, p.128).

Rome, left with no other choice, was compelled to accept the treaty signed by

both parties on October 26, 1896, which was named Addis Ababa. The treaty's most significant provisions included the annulment of the Treaty of Wichale and Italy's recognition of Ethiopia's complete independence. The demarcation of the border between Ethiopia and the Italian colony of Eritrea was postponed for future discussions. In the meantime, both sides agreed to maintain the situation as it was before the outbreak of hostilities, known as the former status quo (Zewde, 2002, p.128). Additionally, Rome later entered into treaties with the emperor in 1900, 1902, and 1908 to establish the border between its newly acquired colony, Eritrea, and Ethiopia (Plaut, 2016, p.9).

The Adwa disaster raised doubts about all past experiences. Additionally, Crespi's political trajectory was destroyed, along with the hopes of the colonial nation he symbolized. The seventy-seven-year-old prime minister was esteemed as one of Europe's foremost political figures. Yet, his impulsive nature tarnished his career, and his actions were frequently described as lacking in knowledge or sound judgment. His grand ideas exceeded the country's capabilities (Pankhurst et al, 2005, p.29).

Crispi's downfall marked the end of his political career, with no chance of a comeback. Moreover, Eritrea's military rule is set to be replaced by a civilian government. Ferdinando Martini faced financial constraints (Choate, 2003, p. 67), ushering in a new chapter in Ethiopia's

diplomatic relations. Rodini, who succeeded Crespi, acknowledged the Treaty of Addis Abeba, officially recognizing Ethiopia as an independent and sovereign nation. The defeat of the Italians at Adwa brought Ethiopia to the forefront of global attention (Baer, 1967, p.5).

Furthermore, the repatriation of the surviving settlers resulted in the cessation of land seizures and distribution in Italy. In an effort to discourage future Italian emigration to Eritrea, the new colonial governor, Ferdinando Martini, implemented a policy requiring a substantial deposit from all Italians traveling to the region (Choate, 2003, p.68).

The repatriation of Italian prisoners captured in Adwa served as a rallying point for the new Italian regime. To facilitate this process, Governor Martini successfully convinced Pope Leo XIII to write a letter to Menelik in May 1896, urging him to show mercy. Menelik agreed to release the prisoners on the condition of signing a peace treaty. In a letter to Menelik, he expressed his reluctance to sacrifice the only guarantee of peace he had as king and father of his people (Zewde, 2002, p.128).

Meanwhile, the captives who settled in the area known as Talian Safar (Italian Quarter) in western Addis Ababa were treated well. Some were even employed in constructing roads and bridges in the growing capital of the empire. An

agreement was reached for the repatriation of Italian prisoners of war (Pankhurst et al, 2005, p.30).

General Baratieri went on trial in June, and while he was eventually acquitted, the words of the ruling painted him as inept. As all Italian soldiers withdrew from Tigray and reassembled in Eritrea, General Baldissera protected the colony and evicted the Dervishes from Jebel Makram a month after the Battle of Adwa. The Italians effectively destroyed 800 of the 5,000-strong invasion army and won following battles with the Mahdists. Kassala was given up to Great Britain in 1897, and the following year, British General Horatio Kitchener led soldiers to a decisive victory over the Mahdists at the Battle of Omdurman (Pankhurst et al, 2005, p.30).

-In Menelik's empire:

Ethiopia's triumph in the Battle of Adwa had a profound impact on Menelik and the nation as a whole. It instilled a deep sense of national pride and strength among Ethiopians, which played a crucial role in fostering a collective consciousness necessary for the stability of the national government. Moreover, this victory elevated Menelik's status both domestically and internationally, attracting new allies and admirers for the country. The reverberations of this triumph were felt across Europe, leading to the downfall of the Italian government (Baer, 1967, p.5). Additionally, Ethiopia's success in the

battle shielded it from the colonial conflicts that ravaged Africa during the 19th century. Menelik further solidified Ethiopia's position by forming an alliance with the French, a diplomatic move that resulted in increased military support from France. As a result, not only the Permanent Army, but also farmers in northern Ethiopia were armed with modern weaponry and ammunition, enabling swift mobilization if needed (Adejumobi, 2006, p30).

The victor reaped immediate and extensive rewards. Following the battle, the Treaty of Wushale was annulled in the subsequent peace negotiations, effectively ending Italy's claimed "protectorate" over Ethiopia. This agreement officially recognized Ethiopia's complete sovereignty and independence. Although the Italians paid a compensation of 5 million in gold, they were allowed to maintain a presence in Eritrea. The price Italy paid for its delayed imperial ambitions was significant in terms of finances, lives lost, military resources, and reputation both domestically and internationally. Conversely, Eritrea bore a heavy financial burden (Pankhurst et al, 2005, p.30).

The Addis Ababa Treaty of 1896 played a crucial role in freeing Ethiopia from the looming Italian threat. This treaty also facilitated the rise of French influence, which became more pronounced during Menelik's reign. The French encouraged Menelik's expansion towards the White Nile. At that time, French policy aimed at

establishing an African empire stretching from the Atlantic Ocean to the Red Sea. The concession granted to Mr. Ilg's Compagnie impériale des chemins de fer d'éthiopie for constructing a railway in Ethiopia, with plans for a route from Jibuti through Harrar, Entotto, Kaffa, and ultimately to the White Nile, reflected this ambition (Stern, 1936, p.194).

Besides Menelik prudently opted not to penetrate into Eritrea. He was the first Ethiopian ruler to deliver a blow to the integrity of the country by yielding the territory to Italian colonization, and he had forfeited all hope of direct access to the sea, but he did have a secure access to the southeast, which was simultaneously weakening of his traditional opponent Tigray. Perhaps he also thought he had to salvage what he possibly could to obliterate the disaster of the Protectorate in which he had to grant control to Italy, perhaps he was concerned that the Italians were intent on reviving the Protectorate, and he desired to avoid the predictable retaliation of a disgraced Western power (Coquery-Vidrovitch & Baker, 2009, p.83).

Additionally, Menelik successfully preserved and expanded Ethiopia's ancient territories, excluding Eritrea. Through uniting leaders from various regions against a common enemy, the emperor laid the foundation for a centralized government that could potentially replace the Ethiopian Orthodox Church as a symbol of national unity. This battle played

a crucial role in the formation of the modern Ethiopian imperial state, setting Ethiopia's future apart from the rest of Africa (Pankhurst et al, 2005, p.31).

4. CONCLUSION:

Italian colonialism exemplifies the aggressive tactics employed by colonial powers to solidify their position on the global stage from the early 19th century until post-World War II. The underlying motivations for this pursuit are evident in the perceived disgraceful narrative that unfolded during Italy's colonial endeavors. Driven by internal factors, such as economic interests, Italy sought to expand its influence beyond its deteriorating Mediterranean cities, which were confined to the northern regions. This expansion was a response to the challenges faced post-unification, including overpopulation, prompting the need to alleviate domestic pressures by seeking new territories for settlement and employment opportunities.

Italy's initial success in establishing colonies in East Africa, particularly in Eritrea and Ethiopia, fueled its ambition for further territorial acquisitions. This ambition clashed with the expectations of Emperor Menelik II, with whom Italy had entered into various agreements and friendship treaties to safeguard mutual interests. However, revelations of Italy's deceitful practices and the Dugali massacre, where numerous Italians were

killed, strained relations between the two parties. The culmination of these tensions led to the Battle of Adwa on March 1, 1896, resulting in a significant defeat for Italy.

This incident had multiple consequences. Firstly, it led to Melnik assuming power and consequently resulted in Ethiopia gaining its independence and reaffirming its sovereignty. This event prompted several countries to swiftly acknowledge Ethiopia as an independent nation. Meanwhile, the Italian influence that remained in Eritrea diminished, and the Wishali Treaty was abolished. Additionally, the Italian presence in the region declined significantly, with Eritrea being the only territory they retained. However, some of the Italian officials faced severe criticism, leading to the resignation of Crespi, the Prime Minister. General Baratieri, who was held accountable for the incident, faced a trial but was ultimately acquitted. Nevertheless, the shame of the defeat continued to haunt him.

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